Tokarenko. “Right now, as we speak with you, ships are already crossing the ocean with our troops, who will help you defend your independence.” The statement made a strong impression on the Cubans, who were pleased to hear the news and discussed it among themselves. It also made a strong but unfavorable impression on General Pliev. The next day Tokarenko was relieved of his duties as division commander for disclosing a state secret. That would be the end of his military career. The Cuban officers who had heard his words were detained to preclude further dissemination of information about the coming Soviet buildup on the island.[12]

The Soviet cargo ships with the R-12 MRBMs that John McCone had been so concerned about during his French vacation and General Tokarenko implied were on their way to save Cuba, began arriving in Cuban ports during the last weeks of August. The first was the cargo ship *Omsk*, which had left Sevastopol harbor on August 5 and arrived in Casilda, a seaside village near the city of Trinidad in central Cuba, on August 19. On board were six R-12 missiles accompanied by the officers and men of Colonel Ivan Sidorov’s 637th missile regiment. As the docks of the Casilda sugar factory could handle only one ship at a time, and there was nowhere to put the missiles and equipment for storage, Sidorov, his men, and their cargo had to stay on board the *Omsk* as it lay at anchor in Casilda harbor. According to Statsenko’s later report, the *Omsk* and those R-12 missiles were finally unloaded on September 9. That day the first MRBM landed on Cuban soil.[13]

General Igor Statsenko, the commander of the missile division, was the first to greet Sidorov and his men in Cuba. He had arrived by air in the third week of July, and by the time Sidorov reached the island, Statsenko had got a suntan, grown a mustache, and, to many, looked like a Cuban. One of the planners of the Anadyr operation, General Anatoly Gribkov, who had met Statsenko before his departure for Cuba and then saw him in action in October, was impressed by his stature: “Young, smart, and dressed, like all the servicemen and officers, in civilian clothes: dark gray pants, short-sleeved check shirt. His flawless military bearing was a delight to see.” Sidorov took an immediate liking to his new commander. “He was a life-loving, energetic and strong-willed general with fine organizational skills